

Guide 62 — Teacher Assistant and Instructional Aide

Controlled English working master — Version 2.0

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What this work is

Teacher assistants and instructional aides help teachers and students with classroom instruction, supervision, routines, materials, documentation, and individual or small-group support. Employers may use titles such as teacher aide, instructional aide, paraprofessional, paraeducator, educational assistant, classroom aide, or learning-support assistant.

This is a **support role**. It is not automatically the same as being the teacher of record, a licensed special-education teacher, school psychologist, counsellor, nurse, therapist, or other regulated professional. Duties, education requirements, school-year schedules, background checks, and permitted support tasks vary by school system and jurisdiction.

In the United States, the Bureau of Labor Statistics reports teacher assistants as a broad occupational group, while Apprenticeship.gov separately identifies the detailed O*NET occupation **25-9042.00 — Teaching Assistants, Preschool, Elementary, Middle, and Secondary School, Except Special Education**. In Canada, the closest national Job Bank classification is **NOC 43100 — Elementary and secondary school teacher assistants**.

Before paying for training or accepting a role, compare the actual posting, employer rules, student population, supervision model, and local education requirements.

What you may do

Depending on the school, student needs, training, supervision, and local rules, duties may include:

- reinforcing lessons or activities prepared by the responsible teacher;
- working with individual students or small groups under teacher direction;
- helping students practise reading, writing, mathematics, language, classroom routines, or other assigned skills;
- preparing learning materials, classroom supplies, displays, worksheets, or approved digital resources;

- helping record attendance, assignments, routine observations, or other authorized information;
- supervising students during arrival, dismissal, lunch, recess, hall transitions, field activities, or other assigned periods;
- supporting classroom organization and positive routines;
- helping students use approved assistive technology or accessible learning materials;
- supporting students with disabilities according to approved plans, training, and professional direction;
- assisting with personal care or mobility only when trained, authorized, and required by the role;
- helping teachers monitor whether students understand directions or complete assigned work;
- communicating factual observations to the responsible teacher or authorized school professional;
- assisting with school events, learning centres, libraries, labs, or activity areas when assigned; and
- escalating academic, behavioural, health, safeguarding, privacy, or safety concerns through the school's approved process.

Good support strengthens the teacher's work without taking over decisions that belong to qualified educators, specialists, administrators, families, or public authorities.

What this role must not be presented as

A teacher assistant or instructional aide should not be described as having independent authority that the role does not carry.

Do not independently:

- act as the teacher of record unless separately qualified and formally assigned under applicable rules;
- diagnose a disability, learning disorder, developmental condition, behavioural condition, or mental-health condition;
- create, alter, or override an Individualized Education Program, accommodation plan, behaviour plan, clinical recommendation, or other formal student-support plan;
- provide psychotherapy, nursing, occupational therapy, physical therapy, speech-language therapy, legal advice, or other regulated professional services unless separately credentialed and authorized;
- promise a student or family a placement, accommodation, grade, disciplinary result, service, benefit, or outcome you do not control;
- make an independent safeguarding or mandatory-reporting decision that school policy or law assigns to a designated authority;

- use restraint, seclusion, medication support, feeding support, toileting assistance, lifting, or other higher-risk procedures without the required training and authorization; or
- ignore a teacher, administrator, specialist, health professional, or approved student plan because you believe a different approach would be better.

When the boundary is unclear, stop and ask the responsible teacher, supervisor, administrator, or qualified professional.

Work environment and physical demands

Teacher assistants commonly work in public or private schools, special-education settings, treatment or support centres, early-learning environments, or other educational programs. Some jobs follow a traditional school calendar. Others include summer programs, extended-day work, transportation duties, or year-round schedules.

The work may involve:

- standing, walking, kneeling, sitting on low furniture, or moving around a classroom for long periods;
- supervising groups in noisy or busy environments;
- helping students transition between activities or locations;
- lifting or physical support in some disability-services roles;
- exposure to common childhood illnesses;
- repeated emotional demands when supporting students who are frustrated, distressed, dysregulated, or facing difficult circumstances; and
- balancing attention among multiple students while following teacher direction.

Special-needs and personal-care assignments may have additional physical, infection-control, behavioural, or safety requirements. Ask about the actual duties before accepting a role.

Safeguarding and emergency boundaries

School employees and support staff may observe or receive disclosures involving abuse, neglect, bullying, self-harm risk, violence, exploitation, medical danger, or other urgent concerns.

Do not invent your own response. Follow the school's approved safeguarding and emergency procedures and applicable law.

Depending on the situation and jurisdiction, this can include:

- notifying the responsible teacher, administrator, safeguarding lead, nurse, or other designated person;
- following mandatory-reporting rules when your role is covered;
- contacting emergency services when required by policy or law;
- documenting what you directly observed or were told, without conducting an unauthorized investigation;
- preserving evidence or information only as instructed; and
- avoiding promises of confidentiality that conflict with legal or safety obligations.

Training material and AI tools are not substitutes for current local safeguarding law or school policy.

Student privacy, records, and confidentiality

Teacher assistants can encounter highly sensitive information, including student names, grades, attendance, disability information, Individualized Education Programs, health information, behaviour records, family details, disciplinary information, immigration-related information, and safeguarding concerns.

In the United States, FERPA rules can permit access by qualifying school officials only when institutional criteria are met and the person has a legitimate educational interest. In every jurisdiction, follow the school's privacy and records rules.

Practical safeguards include:

- access only information needed for your assigned duties;
- use approved school devices, systems, email, messaging, and cloud services;
- verify recipients before sharing student information;
- keep screens, printed records, and conversations private;
- do not photograph, download, copy, or forward student records unless authorized;
- follow retention, disposal, and incident-reporting procedures;
- do not discuss students in public places or on personal social media; and
- report suspected privacy or account compromise promptly.

Write observations factually. Separate what you saw or heard from what a teacher, specialist, parent, or student reported.

Supporting students with disabilities and accessibility needs

Teacher assistants can be important partners in inclusive education. Depending on training and assignment, support may include accessible materials, assistive technology, communication aids, classroom routines, mobility assistance, sensory supports, small-group practice, or implementation of approved accommodations.

The worker should follow the student's authorized plan and professional direction. Do not independently diagnose a disability, prescribe an accommodation, change a formal plan, or decide that a specialist recommendation is unnecessary.

Use respectful, age-appropriate, disability-inclusive language. Ask what support is authorized and needed rather than assuming that every student with the same diagnosis requires the same assistance.

Skills employers may value

Employers often value:

- patience and calm communication;
- ability to follow teacher direction accurately;
- literacy, numeracy, and basic digital skills;
- observation and factual recordkeeping;
- classroom organization;
- positive behaviour support within approved procedures;
- cultural humility and disability-inclusive communication;
- teamwork with teachers, specialists, administrators, and families;
- confidentiality and good judgment;
- reliability, punctuality, and consistent attendance;
- ability to explain directions in plain language;
- de-escalation and emotional self-regulation;
- flexibility when classroom priorities change; and
- willingness to learn school-specific systems and student-support procedures.

Bilingual or multilingual ability can be valuable, but do not claim certified interpretation, translation, or bilingual-education credentials you do not hold.

Education and entry pathways

United States

The U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics reports that teacher assistants typically need at least **two years of college coursework**. In public schools, workers generally need at least two years of college coursework or an associate degree. Exact requirements vary by state, district, school, program, and funding context.

A practical entry sequence is:

1. Review local postings for teacher assistant, instructional aide, paraprofessional, paraeducator, classroom aide, special-education aide, and educational assistant.
2. Record the actual education, assessment, background-check, fingerprinting, first-aid, special-needs, language, and driving requirements.
3. Compare those requirements with community-college, district, public workforce, and employer-supported options.
4. Build relevant experience through supervised school, tutoring, youth, childcare, recreation, disability-support, library, or community programs.
5. Apply only to roles that match your actual training and experience.
6. Consider additional education when it supports a clear employer requirement or advancement path.

The detailed O*NET occupation **25-9042.00** is currently listed by Apprenticeship.gov as **not approved for use in a Registered Apprenticeship Program**. Do not assume a national Registered Apprenticeship pathway exists for this occupation. Individual districts and employers may still provide paid training or work-based development.

Canada

Government of Canada Job Bank classifies elementary and secondary school teacher assistants under **NOC 43100**.

Current national requirements state that completion of secondary school is required and that teacher assistants usually require completion of a **10-month college program** in teaching assistance, educational assistance, or another social-science program. Supporting students with special needs usually requires specialized training and experience.

School-board, provincial, and specialized-program requirements can differ. Verify the exact posting and local rules before enrolling.

Colombia

A clean current one-to-one national occupational classification and official national wage series that maps perfectly to the Guide 62 title was not identified in the controlled research pass. Do not invent one.

SENA can still be a useful public training starting point. Betowa currently lists **Inducción a procesos pedagógicos**, a complementary virtual program of approximately **40 hours** that covers education and pedagogy, teacher/student roles, teaching-learning processes, curriculum, and assessment.

This is **adjacent skill-building**, not a universal legal prerequisite for school instructional-aide work.

SENA's Agencia Pública de Empleo periodically lists roles using titles such as *auxiliar docente*. Use current postings to understand employer-specific education, schedules, experience, duties, and compensation. A single posting is not a national wage benchmark.

Latin America and the Caribbean

Titles, school employment rules, public-training systems, qualification frameworks, and protected professional roles vary widely across the region.

OIT/Cinterfor can help identify the relevant national vocational-training institution or qualification system. Use it as a locator, then verify the actual role, education requirement, cost, recognition, safeguarding rules, and legal scope in the country where you plan to work.

Free-first and low-cost training strategy

Before paying for a private certificate:

1. Review 15–20 real local job postings.
2. Separate legally required qualifications from employer preferences.
3. Ask school districts or employers what training they provide after hire.
4. Check public workforce, community-college, school-district, SENA, or other public options first.
5. Compare tuition, materials, transport, exams, unpaid placements, and schedule requirements.
6. Verify that local employers actually recognize the credential.
7. Get refund and job-placement claims in writing.
8. Avoid debt for a credential that the target employers do not request.

Funding and public training locators

United States

CareerOneStop provides an American Job Center network and a **WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder**. Eligible people may receive support for approved training, but eligibility, local priorities, approved providers, and available funds vary. WIOA funding is **not guaranteed**.

The detailed O*NET occupation 25-9042.00 is not currently shown as approved for Registered Apprenticeship on Apprenticeship.gov. Search current employer and district programs rather than paying a provider that promises a national apprenticeship pathway that does not exist.

Canada

There is no single national funding program that applies to every NOC 43100 role. Compare provincial student aid, college programs, public employment services, school-board training, and employer-supported education in the province where you intend to work.

Confirm public-aid eligibility directly with the responsible government program before enrolling.

Colombia and Latin America

In Colombia, begin with SENA/Betowa and SENA's Agencia Pública de Empleo. In other Latin American countries, use OIT/Cinterfor to identify the relevant national public training body and then confirm current offerings directly.

Employer support and work-based development

Ask employers or school systems about:

- paid onboarding and paraeducator orientation;
- classroom-management and positive-behaviour-support training;
- safeguarding and mandatory-reporting training;
- special-education and disability-support training;
- first aid or CPR when required;
- de-escalation and crisis-response training;
- assistive-technology training;
- language-learning support;
- tuition assistance or reimbursement;
- pathways from paraprofessional work into teacher education; and
- internal promotion or credential-development programs.

Get any repayment obligation in writing before accepting employer-funded education.

Income and employment outlook

United States — official data

The U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics reports for teacher assistants:

- **Median annual wage, May 2024: USD \$35,240**
- **Employment, 2024: approximately 1,422,800**
- **Projected employment change, 2024-2034: -1%**
- **Projected openings: approximately 170,400 per year**

The openings are largely replacement-driven. These are national occupational figures, not guaranteed starting pay.

School-year and part-time schedules can make annual and hourly comparisons misleading. Verify paid weeks, daily hours, benefits, and summer employment before comparing offers.

United States — current private market estimate

Indeed reported an average base pay of approximately **USD \$18.45 per hour** for the narrower title *Teaching Assistant*, updated **August 3, 2026** and based on job-posting salary data.

This is a **non-government market estimate** with a different title and methodology from the BLS occupational median. Do not combine the two as though they are one dataset.

Canada — official data

Government of Canada Job Bank reports national NOC 43100 wages, updated **November 19, 2025**, of approximately:

- **CAD \$18.29/hour low**
- **CAD \$25.01/hour median**
- **CAD \$32.42/hour high**

The wage reference period is 2023–2024. Regional pay and employment prospects vary by province and local labour market.

Colombia

A directly comparable current national official wage series for the exact Guide 62 role was not identified in the controlled research pass. Do not manufacture one.

Use current school, education-provider, and SENA Agencia Pública de Empleo postings to compare compensation, contract type, schedule, education requirements, and duties in your city or department.

A practical 12-week start plan

Weeks 1-2: Review 15-20 local postings. Record recurring education, assessment, background-check, first-aid, disability-support, language, technology, and schedule requirements.

Weeks 3-4: Strengthen literacy, numeracy, plain-language explanation, digital skills, classroom organization, and factual note writing.

Weeks 5-6: Learn basic safeguarding, privacy, disability inclusion, professional boundaries, and school escalation procedures using public or employer-recognized training.

Weeks 7-8: Build supervised experience through tutoring, youth programs, libraries, childcare, recreation, disability services, school volunteering, or community education where appropriate.

Weeks 9-10: Learn how teachers use lesson objectives, classroom routines, small-group support, accessibility tools, and approved student-support plans. Practise only with fictional or non-sensitive examples.

Weeks 11-12: Apply to roles that match your actual education and experience. Prepare examples showing patience, reliability, student support, confidentiality, teamwork, and appropriate escalation.

Building experience without already having the title

Transferable experience can come from:

- tutoring or literacy programs;
- childcare or early-learning settings;
- youth recreation;
- libraries or homework programs;
- disability-support services;
- camps or after-school programs;
- customer service requiring patience and clear explanation;
- community education;
- caregiving; or
- supervised school volunteering where permitted.

Describe experience precisely. Useful evidence includes attendance, number of learners supported, lesson or activity preparation, accurate records, positive feedback, successful small-group support, safe supervision, or use of approved accessibility tools.

Do not claim teacher licensure, special-education authority, counselling expertise, clinical credentials, or independent IEP decision-making unless you actually hold that authority.

Career progression

Possible next steps include senior paraprofessional, special-education aide, educational assistant, learning-support assistant, behaviour-support aide, school program assistant, after-school coordinator, family-engagement support, or other education-support roles.

With additional education and jurisdiction-specific credentials, some people later move into licensed teaching, special education, school counselling, educational technology, student services, or school administration.

Experience alone does not automatically confer a protected professional title or teaching license. Verify the next role's legal and educational requirements before enrolling or representing yourself under that title.

Using AI responsibly in this work

AI can be useful for:

- practising generic interview questions;
- explaining non-sensitive education terminology;
- drafting generic study notes;
- brainstorming classroom-support ideas for teacher review; or
- creating fictional practice scenarios.

Do **not** put identifiable or confidential student information into an unapproved AI tool. This includes student names, education records, IEP details, grades, health information, behaviour records, safeguarding information, family details, or disciplinary information.

AI must not replace licensed teacher or specialist judgment, school safeguarding decisions, formal disciplinary processes, disability determinations, or approved student-support plans. AI-generated educational material should be reviewed by the responsible teacher or authorized professional before use with students.

Follow school policy even when a public AI service appears convenient.

Cybersecurity basics for school support work

Protect student and school information by:

- using unique passwords and multifactor authentication when available;
- locking screens when away from a device;

- using approved school devices and accounts;
- treating unexpected links, attachments, login prompts, and password-reset requests cautiously;
- never sharing passwords or authentication codes;
- avoiding unknown USB drives or unauthorized software;
- keeping sensitive student information out of personal email, messaging apps, personal cloud storage, and unapproved AI tools; and
- reporting suspected phishing, lost devices, privacy incidents, or account compromise promptly.

When to pause before paying for training

Pause or delay enrollment when:

- the provider cannot show that local employers request the credential;
- tuition, fees, materials, exams, transport, or placement costs are unclear;
- job-placement claims cannot be verified;
- the program implies that it grants teacher licensure or protected professional authority when it does not;
- a cheaper public or employer-funded pathway may meet the same requirement;
- refund terms are unclear; or
- the program pressures you to borrow money before you have compared real local job requirements.

Current sources

Official/public sources:

- U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics — Teacher Assistants: [Source link](#)
- Apprenticeship.gov — O*NET 25-9042.00 apprenticeship status: [Source link](#)
- CareerOneStop — WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder: [Source link](#)
- U.S. Department of Education — FERPA school-official access guidance: [Source link](#)
- Government of Canada Job Bank — NOC 43100 requirements: [Source link](#)
- Government of Canada Job Bank — NOC 43100 wages: [Source link](#)
- Government of Canada Job Bank — regional outlook: [Source link](#)
- SENA Betowa — Inducción a procesos pedagógicos: [Source link](#)
- SENA Agencia Pública de Empleo: <https://ape.sena.edu.co/>
- OIT/Cinterfor: <https://www.oitcinterfor.org/>
- OIT/Cinterfor regional training-network locator: [Source link](#)

Supplemental non-government market source:

- Indeed — Teaching Assistant salary estimate: [Source link](#)

Source and review note

This Version 2 master uses current public sources and a clearly separated private market estimate. Source pages, program availability, wages, school rules, and employer requirements can change. Recheck them before making an education, employment, relocation, or financial decision.

Internal project QA and AI-assisted drafting do not constitute independent human certification, professional translation certification, accreditation, legal review, accessibility certification, or a guarantee of employment or earnings.